Eurasia and has been linked to India's approach of seeking a "fairly flexible multilateralism" in its "extended neighbourhood."[1] New Delhi keenly pursued membership in the SCO despite critics at home challenging the wisdom of joining a China-led body as a junior member with a lesser political voice. Even though New Delhi and Beijing have come together at several multilateral forums such as BRICS, East Asia Summit, ASEAN Regional Forum (ARF), and Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB), the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation is a profoundly China-led organisation with a mandate reaching far beyond economic issues. Consequently, it is natural to ask if SCO membership actually holds any direct potential gains for India.

Multilateral institutions are normally regarded as venues to foster stability through closer cooperation, including between India and China.[2] Yet the fact that these two countries engage each other in a number of regional/multilateral organisations could also be a statement of strategic opposition, attempting to deny each other space and holding an edge over each other.[3] In other words, an important aspect to explore is if India through joining the SCO gradually is adapting to a more China-led order in the region or if its entry into the SCO is rather an effort by New Delhi to check and counter China's growing footprint in India's neighbourhood. Or should New Delhi's decision to join the SCO simply be understood as an attempt at increasing its cooperation with China, without any risk of losing its strategic autonomy? Finally, how China driven is India's motivation for joining the SCO? This chapter elaborates on these questions through discussing India's motives for joining the SCO, by looking at India's lengthy entry process into the SCO, and by examining convergence/divergence between Indian and Chinese interests on four issues of importance within the SCO. The four issues are: 1) combating international terrorism, 2) the